

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Earthquake

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

During shaking, Drop, Cover and Hold On. Protect your head and neck beneath a sturdy table if nearby; stay indoors rather than running outside. If near the coast, strong or long shaking may mean tsunami danger: move inland and uphill once shaking stops.

Do now.

- ☐ **Protect yourself now**
01 Drop onto hands and knees and cover your head and neck. With a mobility device, lock wheels and protect your head.
- ☐ **Hold on**
02 Stay under sturdy cover until shaking ends. Keep away from windows and objects that can fall.
- ☐ **If outdoors or driving**
03 Move away from buildings and lines. Pull over safely clear of bridges, wires and trees and remain in the vehicle during shaking.
- ☐ **Check secondary hazards**
04 Expect aftershocks; avoid damaged structures and check for fire, gas leaks and tsunami warnings.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

After shaking, account for people, put on shoes and check from a safe position for fire, gas smell, damaged wiring and instability. Do not reenter a seriously damaged building while waiting for inspection. Expect aftershocks and keep clear of masonry and power lines.

Watch for.

Doorways are not generally the safest shelter. Do not use elevators after damaging shaking.

People & practical needs.

Practice how each person protects their head and body with their actual mobility device or sleeping location. Keep shoes and a light accessible for broken glass afterward. Establish a reunion point without depending on elevators or a working mobile network.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Check injuries and use texts to communicate. Leave a damaged building by stairs when safe and follow official reentry instructions.

Check the next usable option

Check injuries and use texts to communicate. Leave a damaged building by stairs when safe and follow official reentry instructions.

When the first option is unavailable

After shaking, account for people, put on shoes and check from a safe position for fire, gas smell, damaged wiring and instability. Do not reenter a seriously damaged building while waiting for inspection. Expect aftershocks and keep clear of masonry and power lines.

Questions in the field.

Should I run outside during shaking?

Use Drop, Cover and Hold On where you are when the shaking starts, adapting to mobility needs. Moving through falling objects, glass or stairs can add risk. Once shaking stops, assess the safe route rather than rushing automatically.

What if I am near the coast?

Strong or prolonged shaking or sudden unusual sea behavior can be a natural tsunami warning. After shaking, follow the tsunami route to higher ground or inland when safe, without waiting for an electronic alert. Check the separate Tsunami guide.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Earthquake · official guidance

<https://www.ready.gov/earthquakes>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/earthquake/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.